

FIRST WAVE

3 zombies (MM 316) ([PICTURE](#)) rush forward to attack the characters closest to them. They start by grappling the target. If the target is grappled, they use their slam attack.

SECOND WAVE

4 zombies arrive using the same tactics as above, along with **1 skeleton** (MM 272) that hangs back and fires with its shortbow.

THIRD WAVE

8 zombies from deeper inside the horde join the fray, along with **2 skeletons**. Same tactics as above.

FOURTH WAVE

13 zombies, **1 skeleton**, and **1 skaab goliath** (APPENDIX B) ([PICTURE](#)). Same tactics as above, while the goliath wades into battle swinging its morningstar. This is close to the horde's center.

FIFTH WAVE

20 zombies, **5 skeletons**, **2 skaab goliaths**, and **Rinelda Smitt** (APPENDIX B) ([PICTURE](#)). This is the horde's center.

Same tactics as above. Rinelda tries to stay out of melee. She prefers to first cast *spiritual weapon* and *sacred flame* on her first turn, and on the following turn try to disable the most threatening adventurer with *hold person*. If pressed into melee, she casts *inflict wounds*.

DEVELOPMENTS

Deduct any destroyed undead from the horde's total. Write down which undead were destroyed so you can update the horde's numbers in the upcoming siege.

If at any point the characters flee, the undead chase for

a few rounds before returning to their previous position.

If Rinelda is defeated, the horde carry out their last command and still march in the direction of Shadowgrange, but fifty zombies wander the wrong way and are deducted from the horde's total.

Rinelda Smitt is insane. The teen lost her parents at a very young age and has survived in the wilderness purely off her talents in necromancy. She is devoid of empathy for her victims, seeing humans as useful only as resources to raid for food, clothing, shelter, and their corpses for undead. The only thing she understands and respects is power. If her life is on the line, she'll explain her partnership with Siegfried, and how she's culling the land to bring him corpses for his experiments (see "The Horde's Purpose"). Rinelda respects Siegfried's talents and hopes to learn everything she can as his apprentice before inevitably murdering him and taking over his residence.

Rinelda carries basic necessities (clothing, food) along with a *ghoulcaller's bell* (APPENDIX A) ([PICTURE](#)), and a large pouch containing 90 gp and 70 sp. On her person is a note written by Siegfried, reminding the teen to collect everything she can find in his shop's basement, from papers to alchemical supplies.

DEFENDING SHADOWGRANGE

If the characters choose to defend the town, they can spend the time before the horde arrives by preparing the town's defenses. Let the characters lead the discussion on what to do during this time. The council members respect the opinions of capable adventurers, especially when it comes to battle, and they'll follow the party's initiative for planning.

Adventurers are a delightfully creative and unpredictable bunch and you should encourage their plans if reasonable. Reward good planning, whatever it may be. In addition to the character's ideas, the council members also voice opinions on what to do. These preparation quests will yield benefits in the battle to come (see "Running the Siege"):

- **Warding the Walls.** Priestess Flora thinks she can re-ignite the holy wards that used to protect Shadowgrange's walls, but she'll need help doing so. Any character with proficiency in Intelligence (Religion) can choose to aid her in performing the holy rituals to infuse the walls with holy energy. If at least one character does, Flora and that character can re-arm the wards by spending eight hours devoted to carrying out the ritual. Each additional character aiding in the ritual reduces the time required by four hours. *On success:* The walls radiate a faint divine magic. Lesser undead, such as zombies and skeletons, are repelled from getting too close, and the skaab goliaths in "Assault on the Gate" scenario take longer



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to destroy the gate.

- **Finding Runners.** Captain Levi suggests finding suitable messengers amongst the conscripted townsfolk to relay information between the characters and council members. This way they can better coordinate their defences during the battle. Any character can approach a townsfolk to be a runner. Convincing a person to take the job requires a Charisma (Diplomacy) check DC 10. *On success:* The characters have messengers to keep them informed of how the battle progresses. In the “Defending the Breach” scenario, they characters can arrive earlier, saving more defenders and are rewarded with an additional influence dice.
- **Boosting Morale.** Eckhardt Sheck knows that the conscripted townsfolk are terrified of the approaching horde. These people are not fighters; they are farmers, shepherds, and tradesmen. They need a confidence boost to have them perform well in battle. Any character can try to raise the hopes of the conscripted townsfolk. They can do so in numerous ways, from a rousing speech, playing up the strengths of the adventurers, showing the commoners how to properly wield their weapons, squashing any talks of hopelessness, or any other reasonable idea the characters come up with. An appropriate skill check DC 15 inspires confidence in the conscripts witnessing this. *On success:* Defenders that witness the character’s actions are inspired, fighting more effectively in the siege, dealing more damage to the skaab goliaths in the “Assault on the Gate” scenario.
- **More Conscripts.** Captain Levi points out that the undead horde still greatly outnumber the defenders. To help increase the chances of survival, a weapon should be put into the hands of any person that can hold it. Levi suggests more aggressively conscripting any person able to wield a weapon, including children and the elderly. It will take convincing on the part of the characters to make this happen, however, as parents will be reluctant to send their young ones to battle. As in the “Boosting Morale” quest, the characters can be creative with their ways and pass an appropriate skill DC to conscript the children and elderly. *On success:* The characters can conscript up to 50 additional young and elderly commoners. These commoners help deal additional damage to the skaab goliaths in the “Assault on the Gate” scenario.

Add any other quests that you feel are appropriate to the situation.

As the characters go about preparing, so do the rest of the townsfolk. Shadowgrange’s cathars calls upon all able-bodied citizens to take up arms against the



oncoming attack. These conscripted commoners gather in the town square bringing whatever weapons they have, from hunting bows to pitchforks, where they await orders.

The rest of the townsfolk rush to evacuate precious belongings from their outlying homes and farms to the safety of Shadowgrange’s walls. Noncombatants are squeezed into the town chapel, which is reinforced with makeshift barricades.

Once the civilians are accounted for, the cathars and conscripted soldiers will work day and night to reinforce the gate and build makeshift barricades along the main path leading to the market square.

Free Pots. The clergy members seek out the adventurers. They are well aware that the characters’ prowess will play a critical factor in defending the town, so they give them four *healing potions* for the fight.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 900 XP equally among the characters if the party aids the town in preparing defenses.

EVACUATION?

This adventure assumes most parties will decide to stand their ground and defend Shadowgrange. However, they can choose to flee from the oncoming undead horde. Or perhaps they evacuate the town, lure the undead inside, and then set the place on fire, destroying both the town but also the horde if done correctly. There is no “wrong” way to attack this problem.

Should the characters choose to flee or evacuate, there are a few settlements not far from Shadowgrange that they can travel to. None have the defensible stone walls of Shadowgrange, but all are encircled by a moat and some sort of physical barrier, such as wooden palisades or at the very least somewhat defensible trenches. The closest settlement is a day away.

There are two notable settlements fairly close to Shadowgrange. The first is Lammas, a rancher community stable village two days away. The second is Silbern, a

small community built around Silbern Tower, a lodging and base of operations for a local group of cathars called the Silbern Guard. Three days away, this community has the largest concentration of cathars in Stensia, with a little over a hundred trained fighters ready to take up arms.

It's dangerous to travel through Stensia, as the adventurers probably know already. You may wish to run some of the random encounters from Part 1 while the characters travel to other settlements. Lesser undead, fiends, beasts, and bandits roam preying on travelers.

The zombie horde is on a rampage through the entire countryside. Their sole purpose is to slay the living and return the corpses back to Siegfried in Mauer Estate. If the characters retreat from Shadowgrange, the horde continues moving south, slaughtering all communities along the way. Any settlement in the outland valleys of Stensia will be attacked eventually. Maybe the adventurers team up with the Silbern Guard and take on the horde at a different location. Roll with the player's ideas and it will all work out in the end.

RUNNING THE SIEGE

An undead army marches on Shadowgrange and its defenders are prepared to meet them in battle. Keeping track of hundreds of combatants, including their individual stats and rolls, would be impossible. Instead, it's recommended to run the siege by keeping the adventures and their personal action as the focus like any other battle, with the greater battle around them being told mostly through story rather than dice rolls.

With this method, the battle rages on as a backdrop: the focus is on the fight between the characters and their enemies. The larger conflict takes place "offstage," and is only relevant to the extent that it helps or hinders the characters.

The adventurers will act as Shadowgrange's elite defense unit in the battle, sent to deal with the toughest, most dangerous missions. The result of these missions will determine the ultimate fate of Shadowgrange itself.

Don't bother tracking the hit points of the various combatants, except the ones the adventurers are actively fighting. Just describe the carnage as the defenders and horde battle it out, while the characters take on the toughest part of the enemy forces. A short sentence or



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two at the end of a round or the end of a battle is great to maintain the players' awareness of the ongoing battle around them and keeps them immersed.

THINNING THE NUMBERS

If the PCs destroyed some of the advancing horde in "Attacking the Horde" or otherwise, deduct the destroyed creatures from the horde's total numbers here. If the adventurers destroyed any of the three skaab goliaths, some of the following encounters need to be changed:

- If one goliath was destroyed prior to the siege, then there is no goliath present at the "Defending the Breach" battle, making it much easier.
- Any additional skaab goliaths destroyed prior to the siege (up to three) are subtracted from the "Assault on the Gate" battle, which gives a huge advantage to hold the gate.

HORDE TACTICS

The undead horde's attack comes during the dead of night, where they can take advantage of their darkvision. Shadowgrange's defenders have at least the light of the stars and the moon to see by, along with torches lining their walls to illuminate anyone beside their defenses. The attack is led by Rinelda Smitt, a necromancer herding the horde towards Shadowgrange.

The horde's attack is organized into stages, detailed below. The actions of the characters can disrupt these stages; they are presented here as they would play out if the characters weren't on hand to aid in Shadowgrange's defense.

Stage 1: The undead horde advances on Shadowgrange. The majority of zombies, led by two skaabs, shambles forward to break down the gate, while skeleton archers fire at any defenders they see.

Stage 2: A secondary force of undead attacks led by one skaab breaches the wall, away from the main fighting at the gate.

Stage 3: Swarms of undead pour through gaps in the city defenses created by the skaabs and begin wreaking havoc.

Stage 4: The undead horde fully enters Shadowgrange, routing the defenders to the chapel.

Stage 5: Rinelda Smitt personally leads an assault on the chapel, looking to finish off the remaining defenders.

ASSAULT ON THE GATE

The horde are traversing the valley and approaching

Shadowgrange. It's night, and none of the defenders (except maybe an adventurer) has darkvision to see. Unless the adventurers are attacking, or have provided the other defenders a way to see the approaching horde, Captain Levi orders his crossbowmen and archers to hold fire until they can get a clear shot.

If the adventurers ride out to attack the approaching horde, use the stats given in "Attacking the Horde" section earlier.

When the horde ([PICTURE](#)) arrives at the walls, read or paraphrase:

They arrive in the dead of night: hundreds of shambling humanoids. In the moonlight, their figures silhouettes can be seen, along with glimpses of their rotted faces. As they near the walls, torches illuminate their hideous appearances. The zombies move towards Shadowgrange with a strange urgency; splashing and flailing in the moat's waters, scrambling over each other to reach the walls, lashing at the gate, tearing, ripping, growling.

Lumbering forward, towering over the other zombies, are two stitched abominations. Six powerful arms and three heads are attached to each mass of muscle. These creatures stride easily through the moat's waters and move towards Shadowgrange's gates, where they start pummeling it with armor-plated fists, shaking the barricade with each blow. Captain Levi begins to yell and wave a torch to get attention. "Bowmen! Take out those beasts! Now!"

2 skaab goliaths (APPENDIX B) ([PICTURE](#)) begin leading the attack on the gate. They smash the gate each round, unless something prevents them from doing so. The gate can take 10 hits (or 5 rounds of both hitting) total from the skaabs before being breached. Captain Levi is aware of the danger they pose and barks out orders to take them down. If the adventurers completed the quest "Warding the Walls," the gate instead can take 12 hits total before being breached.

The defenders on the walls begin raining down crossbow bolts and arrows upon the goliaths, dealing 22 damage per round divided between the two goliaths unless specifically told to aim at one. If the adventurers completed the quest "Boosting Morale" or "More Conscripts," the damage per round is increased by 4 per quest completed.

To make matters worse, as the order is given to bring down the goliaths, screams can be heard from atop the walls. **20 skeleton archers** (MM 272) pepper the bowmen atop the walls, using their darkvision to fire from 40 feet away. The constant barrage hampers the defender's ability to take down the goliaths.

For every five skeletons the adventurers take out, the defending bowmen can fire more freely, increase their

damage on the goliaths by +2 each round.

DEVELOPMENTS

If the skaab goliaths are taken out before the gate is breached by them, then the gate holds. Regular zombies stumble over the fallen goliaths to claw at the gate, but their assault is far weaker than the skaab's.

If the gate is breached, all is not lost. Eckhardt and his soldiers, a mix of cathars and conscripts, stand ready to meet the surge of undead that rush through the broken gate. Their goal is to drive the undead back long enough to repair the broken gate.

Regardless of the outcome, a messenger runs over to the adventurers shortly after either the gate is saved/breached. The bloodied soldier comes bearing grim news: one of the far side walls have been breached. The undead are breaking through, and her squadron of soldiers have been taking heavy losses trying to hold their position. Captain Levi will ask the adventurers to reinforce the breach.

If the adventurers completed the quest "Finding Runners," the messenger is one of the people the

characters enlisted as a runner, and they're given an earlier warning that a wall is soon to be breached.

DEFENDING THE BREACH

The undead have breached one of the walls and have begun pouring in. Without the adventurers intervening at the breach, that position will almost assuredly be overrun. If the gate has been breached and the adventurers decide to defend it instead, you can configure the following encounter to work for that too.

Once the adventurers arrive at the breach, read or paraphrase:

The warm glow of fire can be seen over the rooftops ahead of you, where the sounds of fighting can be heard. As you turn the corner, you see two wooden cabins aflame next to the wall, illuminating the scene in front of you. Fighting amidst the bright glow in a tight formation are the cathars, clashing with dozens of undead humanoids. More still

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pour into the street from a breach in the wall 10 feet wide, clambering over the stone debris and eagerly rushing to the living defenders. “By Avacyn’s Might, we hold!” shouts a cathar, even as the soldiers are slowly pushed back.

If the adventurers leave for the breach quickly, then they find a heated battle between the invading undead and the village defenders. A dozen soldiers fight here against ever-increasing numbers of zombies. These eleven cathars started as **guards** (MM 347), along with a single clergy member (treat her as a **priest** [MM 348] without Divine Eminence, no 2nd or 3rd level spells, and only 10 HP). If the adventurers took their time getting here, or didn’t complete the “Finding Runners” quest, five of these cathars are dead when they arrive.

The cathars’ goal is to push the undead out long enough to barricade the breach, but they don’t have the numbers to do so. Only with the adventurer’s help in the fight can they hope to accomplish their task.

OPTIONAL: INFLUENCE DICE

In this battle, the adventurers are given their own targets to eliminate while the cathars fight their own battles with the undead in the background. To help illustrate the fight, you may consider using this optional Influence Dice mechanic, where the combatants in the backdrop can still influence the party’s battle while still being rolls-light.

Represent the background defender’s influence in the fight with two Ally Dice (d6’s), or only one dice if five cathars are already dead. Represent the background undead’s influence with three Enemy Dice.

At the end of each round, roll the dice for each side. For every 6 in the result, that side does something that affect’s the party’s fight. If the 6 is a result of the Ally Dice roll, it’s a help; if it’s a result of the Enemy Dice roll, it’s a hindrance.

For every result of 5, that side does something that affects the party’s fight, but at a negative cost to themselves.

Possible effects include:

Help	Hindrance
A cathar fires a crossbow bolt into an enemy that one of the characters is engaged with. The enemy takes 4 damage.	A zombie catches a character unaware with a slammed fist into its back, dealing 4 damage.
A gust of spectral wind is felt as the spirit of Saint Traft materializes on the battlefield and swings his greatsword at the PC’s enemy, dealing 2d6+5 damage and knocking the target prone, before his spirit is swept away elsewhere by the wind.	One zombie or skeleton joins the battle.
The clergy member rushes over to a wounded character and casts <i>cure wounds</i> , healing 7 hit points, before rejoining the cathars in the background battle.	Zombies dogpile on one of the cathars and start devouring his flesh as his comrades fight desperately to save him.
A cathar joins the party’s battle, rushing to help the most wounded looking character.	The upper half of a zombie latches onto a random PC’s legs, restraining the PC. Strength check DC 10 to escape the restraint.

WAVES OF UNDEAD

In order to hold the line and drive the undead back, the characters must defeat several waves of increasingly dangerous attackers while the cathars fight their own undead foes in the background. Allow each wave’s resulting combat to play out, then let the next wave arrive one or two rounds after. This gives the characters a small window to ready themselves for the next fight. Alternatively, if the characters are finding combat too easy, you can have subsequent waves arrive faster.

FIRST WAVE

3 zombies (MM 316) rush forward to attack the characters closest to them, along with **3 skeletons** (MM 272) that hang back and fire at the characters with their shortbows.

If you are using Influence Dice, remove one of the Enemy Dice after the party defeats the first wave.